

ODISHA FC

SPORTS

THE BEAUTIFUL GAME

CLIFFORD MIRANDA STANDS VINDICATED AS THE COACH WHO HELPED ODISHA FC CLINCH ITS FIRST SUPER CUP

It's

a day Clifford Miranda won't forget in a hurry. On March 16, he was handed the reins of Odisha FC, after the departure of their Spanish head coach, Josep Gombau. There was this unsaid pressure ahead of the Super Cup, especially after Odisha's stellar season where they finished sixth on the table to make the Indian Super League (ISL) playoffs for the first time. However, results were the last thing on Miranda's mind. "My goal was to convince the players that I am the man to take them forward," says Miranda.

Miranda was aware of what previous coach Josep Gombau had achieved, but he was also clear that he wanted to imprint his own style

The wait wasn't long for Odisha. On April 25, they clinched their first silverware after beating Bengaluru FC 2-1 in the final of the Super Cup. And a few days later, they continued their winning run against last season's I-League champions, Gokulam Kerala FC, to qualify for the group stages of the AFC Cup later this year.

"To represent India in Asian club competition is huge," says Miranda. He would know. During his playing days, the midfielder was a part of the Dempo SC side that made the semi-final of the AFC Cup in 2008—a first for Indian football. He spent over a decade with the Goan club, winning the domestic league on five occasions. When he finally called it a day in 2017, he immediately jumped at a coaching opportunity with FC Goa's youth development programme. "I wanted to stop playing when I was still good. I had done my licences by then and my intent was to develop footballers," he says.

After winning the Goa Professional League with the reserve side of FC Goa and picking up the ISL League Winners Shield as interim coach of the senior team, Miranda moved to Odisha as assistant coach at the start of last season. Once handed the top job, he was aware of what Gombau had achieved, but he was also clear that he